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A Context Sensitive State Design Manual

Although some states have included sections on context sensitive design (CSD) in their roadway design manuals, the influence of CSD currently is limited until all state departments of transportation amend standards in their design manuals to permit greater flexibility in road design. This study seeks to determine the degree to which states permit CSD. Design standards for several specific elements on urban principal arterials were reviewed for all 50 states. The design elements include: travel lane width, shoulder width, parking lane width and intersection curb radius. Land use classification and design speed are also considered. For each element, the position taken in A Policy on Geometric Design of Highways and Streets, 5th Edition (AASHTO Green Book) is summarized along with the position adopted in the state design manual. The findings indicate that many states are not using the flexibility offered by the Green Book. However, the Green Book also does not take a very context sensitive approach to some elements. Revisions for state design manuals and the Green Book are suggested.

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